



MEDIA &
ENTERTAINMENT



Spotify hints at a more chatty voice AI interface in the future

Spotify has experimented with various voice interfaces in the past, and more recently, added an AI DJ that introduces tunes the company thinks you'll like and lets you make your own requests. Now, Spotify is teasing that generative AI advances may pave the way for an even more conversational interface with the streaming service in the future, according to comments made during Spotify's second-quarter earnings call with investors on Tuesday.

Asked about how AI was affecting its business, Spotify Chief Product and Technology Officer Gustav Söderström noted that consumers today are able to talk to Spotify in plain English to request music, allowing the company to associate which phrases connect with which songs.

"You can think of it as us getting a new dataset," he said. "Spotify's got this unique dataset from all of its playlists, which was really song-to-song — like which song goes well with another song, kind of the Amazon 'people who bought this also bought that,'" he said. Meanwhile, the voice interface is delivering new insights to the company.

"And that's completely new to us, and it's a very, very valuable dataset that we are collecting very quickly," he added.

As a result, the exec says we can expect Spotify's consumer experiences to get "much more interactive."

"You can already write to Spotify, talk to Spotify. You're just going to see that expand," Söderström said.

Plus, AI technology would allow Spotify to do more than just predict what someone might want to listen to, whether music, podcasts, or audiobooks, as it does today. Instead of only making predictions, it would be able to "reason" over the user's listening history and what they said to the AI DJ. The reference to reasoning suggests that Spotify is looking toward AI reasoning models that can perform more complex tasks across multiple steps.

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The voice data in question comes from Spotify's AI DJ feature. In May 2025, [Spotify introduced a way](#) for Premium subscribers to make voice requests to the English-language AI DJ by pressing a button in the app. This lets users change the music, the genre, or the mood of a playlist using a voice command.

Consumer features aren't the only way Spotify is leveraging AI. During the call, the exec also mentioned that Spotify is using generative AI internally to more rapidly prototype products and create efficiencies in other areas of its business, like finance.

In the quarter, Spotify [hit 276 million paying subscribers](#), up 12% year-over-year, and 696 million monthly active users, but swung to a loss after missing revenue targets. The stock [fell 10% on weak guidance](#) and Spotify CEO Daniel Ek's comments about his unhappiness with the company's ads business.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

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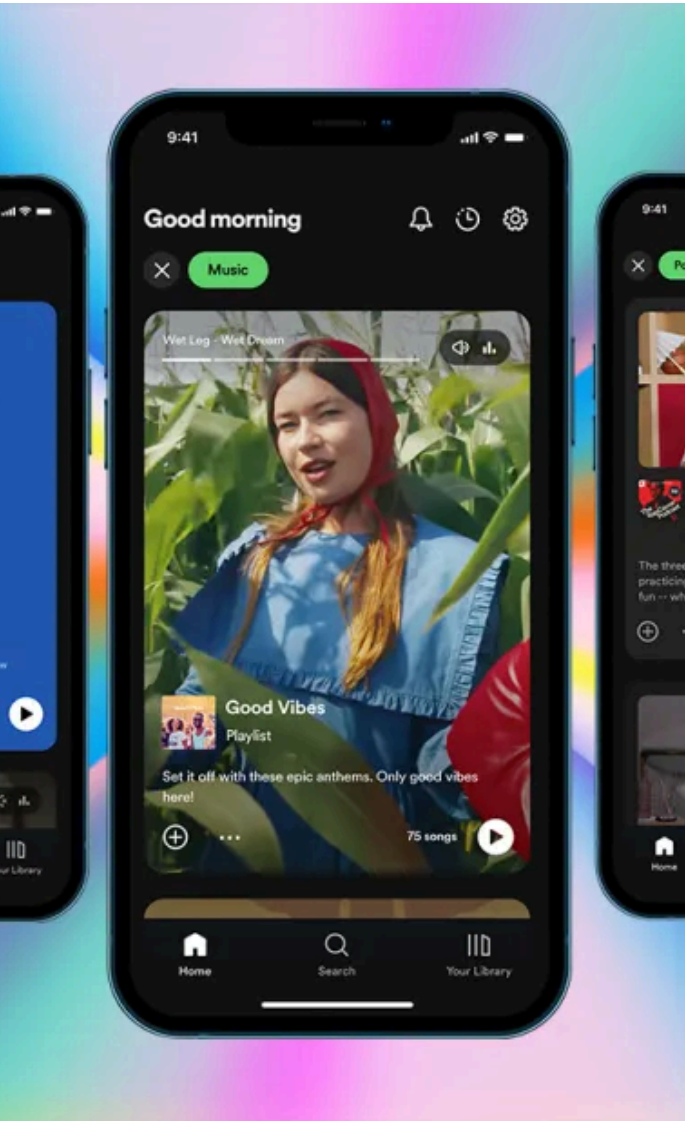


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AI

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Spotify CEO says AI progress is both ‘really cool and scary,’ may pose risk to creative industry

Sarah Perez — 10:23 AM PDT · April 25, 2023

In its [first-quarter earnings call](#), streaming music service Spotify talked in more detail about how AI advances are impacting its business. On the positive side, the company offered an update on the user adoption of its [new AI DJ feature](#), which offers personalized music selections introduced by a realistic-sounding [DJ voice](#) powered by AI. But other AI advances have the potential to cause harm — including the use of AI to create music that clones the voices of existing artists without their consent, leading to copyright concerns and further complications for streamers like itself.

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The latter issue recently made headlines when [a song that used artificial intelligence to clone the voices of Drake and The Weeknd](#) was uploaded to a number of streaming services, including Spotify, Apple Music, Tidal, YouTube, and Deezer.

[A new Drake x The Weeknd track just blew up — but it’s an AI fake](#)

Spotify and others quickly took the track down but faced criticism from publishers like Universal Music Group, which asked which “side of history” did “stakeholders in the music ecosystem want to be on: the side of artists, fans, and human creative expression, or the side of deep fakes, fraud, and denying artists their due compensation?”

On the Q1 2023 investor call, Spotify was asked how it intended to approach this sort of problem going forward.

In response, Spotify CEO Daniel Ek called the issue complex and fast-moving and didn’t seem to have a proposed solution at this time.



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“First off, let’s acknowledge that this is an incredibly fast-moving and developing space. I don’t think in my history with technology I’ve ever seen anything moving as fast as the development of AI currently is at the moment,” he said.

Ek noted that Spotify had to balance two objectives, including being a platform for allowing innovation around creative

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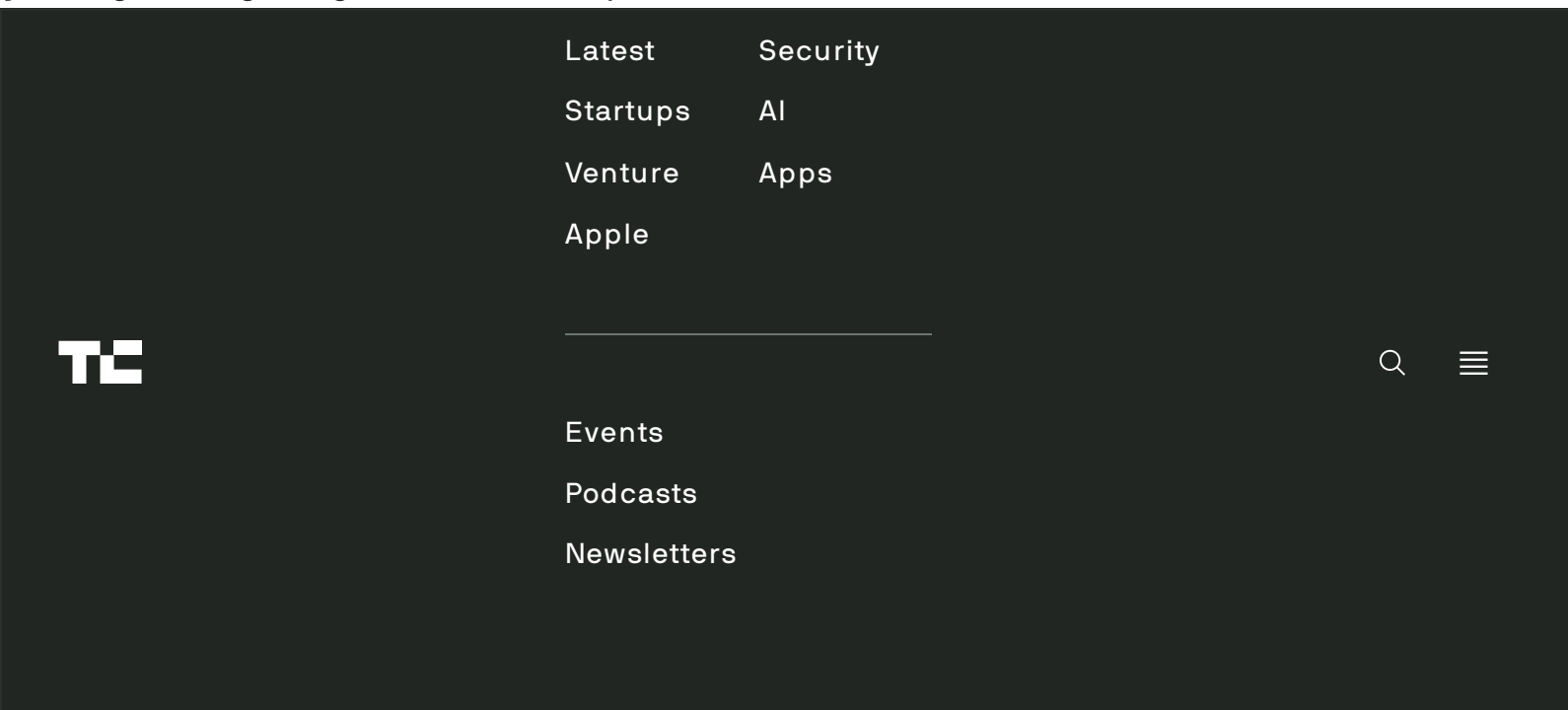
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works, and one that needs to protect existing creators and artists. Both roles it takes very seriously, he said.

“We’re in constant dialogue with the industry about these things. And it’s important to state that there’s everything from...fake tracks from artists which falls in one bucket to... just augmenting using AI to allow for expression, which



to figure out [AI] training...I would definitely put that on the risk account because there’s a lot of uncertainty, I think, for the entire ecosystem,” he said.

Meanwhile, the company is benefiting from the use of AI in other areas, Ek stressed.

For example, Spotify’s recently launched AI DJ feature has been gaining traction.

The feature is still in its early days, having only begun rolling out to Spotify users ahead of its product launch event [Stream On](#) in March, where the company also introduced a revamped, [video-focused user interface](#), powered by algorithms and machine learning, and new tools for artists and podcasters, among other things.

Though limited to the North American market and still in beta, the AI DJ is now reaching “millions” of active users every week, Spotify reported, representing more than 25% of user consumption on days that they use the DJ feature.

That’s solid traction for the still experimental new feature and also a positive indication of the benefit of Spotify’s investment in AI technologies.

The CEO also spoke to AI's potential to help people create music without having to understand how to use complicated music production tools. He envisioned artists instructing the AI to make a song sound "a little more upbeat," just using a voice command, for example, or telling the AI to "add some congas to the mix."

"That has the chance I think, to meaningfully augment that creative journey that many artists do," he noted.

Ek also felt it was important to stress the difference between something like an AI-powered feature like the DJ and the concerns around AI in creating fake tracks.

"I do think it's important to kind of separate AI DJ from the AI conversation. So AI DJ, in and of itself — I think we've had nothing but positive reactions from across the industry. I think the AI pushback from the copyright industry or labels and media companies...it's really around really important topics and issues like name and likeness; what is an actual copyright; who owns the right to something where you upload something and claim it to be Drake, and it's really not; and so on. And those are legitimate concerns," Ek said.

"And obviously, those are things that we're working with our partners on trying to establish a position where we both allow innovation but, at the same time, protect all of the creators that we have on our platform," Ek said.

The company reported its Q1 revenue was up 14% year-over-year to €3.04 billion, and its ad revenue was up 17% year-over-year to €329 million. Spotify hit a new milestone with the news it has reached 500 million users, but its premium subscriber portion [fell to a ratio of 40%](#) paid-to-free listeners, with 210 million premium subscribers and 317 million on the ad-supported plan.

[Spotify passes 500M users, but its premium subscriber portion falls to 40%](#)

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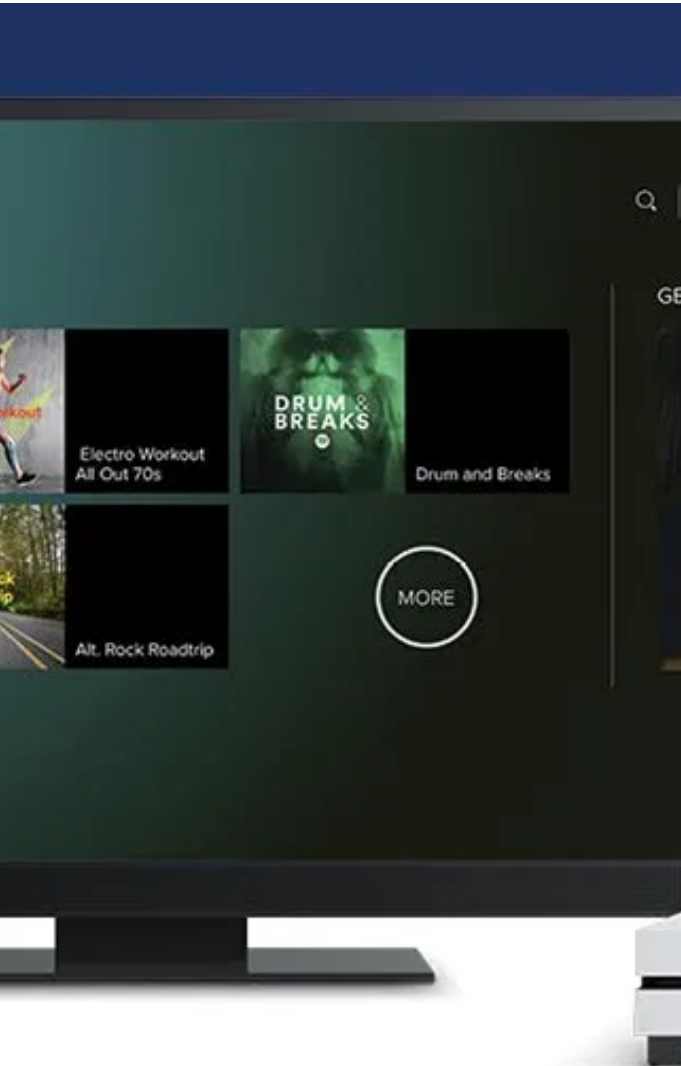
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Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [t](#) [@](#) [in](#)

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Spotify for Xbox One now works with Cortana voice commands

Sarah Perez — 8:00 AM PST · December 5, 2018

Spotify arrived on the Xbox One [back in August 2017](#) to give gamers the option of streaming their own tunes while in a gaming session. Today, Spotify is upgrading its app with a few key additions, including most notably support for Cortana voice control, along with other personalization features. With Cortana, gamers will be able to speak their music requests

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Instead of using the controller. That means they can command the music — including being able to play, skip and pause songs — without having to leave their current gaming session, Spotify says.

Before, gamers would have to use [Spotify Connect](#) via an app on their phone, tablet or laptop to control or change the music while gaming.

For example, you'll be able to say things like "Hey, Cortana, play my playlist on Spotify," or "Hey Cortana, play my Discover Weekly on Spotify."

This upgrade is currently only available in the U.S., however.

The new app is also introducing an updated experience that's designed to make it easier for Spotify users to access recently played songs, plus your "Made for You" hub, and your music library.

Previously, Xbox One users only had access to basic Spotify controls, like play, pause, and skip plus visuals like the cover art and artist and song name. Now, they have personalized content recommendations, and the ability to playback content right from the Guide menu.

This part of the update is rolling out more broadly, including the U.S., as well as in Argentina, Australia, Austria, Belgium, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Colombia, Czech Republic, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hong Kong, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, Japan, Mexico, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Singapore, Slovakia, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Taiwan, Turkey and the U.K.

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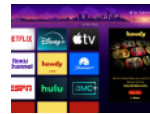
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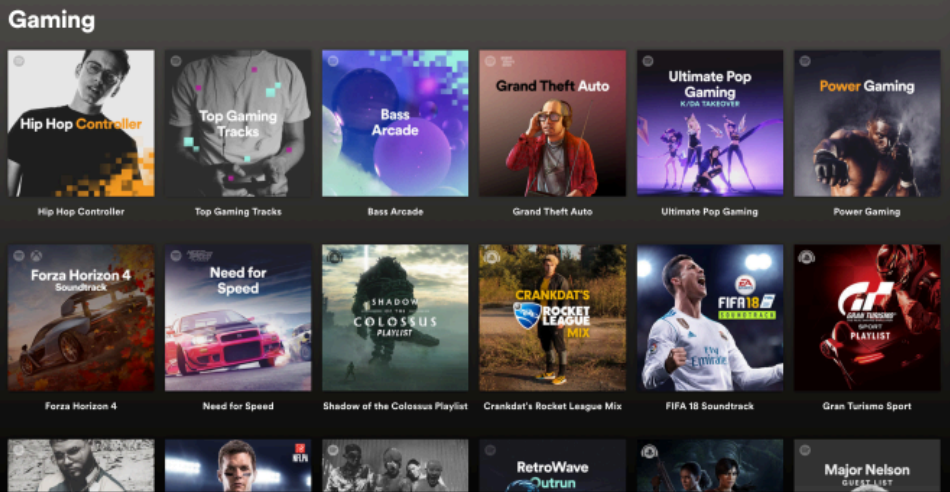
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Options like repeat and shuffle are available, too, as are a selection of curated gaming playlists, over on Spotify’s “[Gaming Hub](#)” if you get stumped as to what to play.

In the future, updates to this Enhanced Background Mode, as Spotify calls the new experience, may include the ability to promote game specific content for major game launches, Spotify says.

The update will require the latest version of the Spotify app, which can be downloaded from the Microsoft Store, the company notes.

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Sarah Perez
Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

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